MARIÑEIROS (1936): TRACING A LOST GALICIAN DOCUMENTARY FILM BETWEEN REPUBLIC AND REGIME

Abstract

This study reconstructs the production and distribution of Mariñeiros (1936), a now-lost documentary film by filmmaker and photographer José Suárez that explores Galician maritime culture. Filmed in the final months of Spain's Second Republic, the project was interrupted by the outbreak of the Civil War. The footage was clandestinely taken to Argentina, where Suárez completed the postproduction in exile and premiered the film in Buenos Aires in 1938. It was subsequently reappropriated without the author's consent: first as Falangist propaganda, and later within the commercial distribution circuit in Spain during the early postwar period.

The project situates Mariñeiros within the shifting political landscape of the 1930s and early 1940s, in which regional representations retained a cultural resonance that facilitated their reinscription across changing political contexts. Although the film is lost, its trajectory can be partially reconstructed through a constellation of non-filmic sources including an eponymous photographic series produced by Suárez in tandem with the film's creation, contemporaneous press coverage, and institutional records documenting its circulation. By analyzing non-filmic materials as productive sources, this study challenges conventional historiographical approaches that privilege preserved works and asks how film history can be written in the absence of the film itself.

Keywords: Mariñeiros, José Suárez, CIFESA, Spanish Civil War, documentary film

Introduction

This study reconstructs the production and distribution of *Mariñeiros* (1936), a now-lost documentary film by Galician filmmaker and photographer José Suárez (1902–1974). Conceived with a strong aesthetic sensibility, *Mariñeiros* portrays the labor and landscape of a fishing community on the Galician coastal town of Bueu. Funded and distributed by the Compañía Industrial Film Española (CIFESA), then Spain's leading film production company, *Mariñeiros* emerged at a time in which the camera turned its gaze toward rural Spain. It was intended as the first installment in a series dedicated to Galician trades—*Oleiros*, *Canteiros*, and *Feirantes*—but the project was cut short by the Spanish Civil War, and only *Mariñeiros* was completed.

Suárez began filming in 1936, just months before the outbreak of the Spanish Civil War. The military coup that summer interrupted production, and shortly thereafter, Suárez went into exile in Argentina, where he was able to recover and complete the project. After a production process fraught with setbacks, *Mariñeiros* premiered in Buenos Aires in July 1938. Just a few months later, in September of the same year, it was screened again—this time as part of a Falangist fundraising event in Buenos Aires. Carried out without the filmmaker's consent, the film's appropriation continued with its subsequent circulation in Spain: between 1941 and 1944, the documentary—omitting Suárez's name as director—was widely exhibited under the new regime. As this study will show, such recontextualization was not uncommon and reflects how authorship and meaning were subject to transformation during the consolidation of the new political order.

The trajectory of *Mariñeiros* thus spans a period of profound historical transformation: conceived during the Republic, interrupted by the Civil War, completed in exile, and later appropriated in the early years of Francoism. Despite its cultural significance, the film survives only through non-filmic traces: a parallel photographic series, also titled *Mariñeiros*, in which Suárez captured the same scenes and characters of the film; institutional records; and references in the press. The film's loss has contributed to the exclusion of *Mariñeiros* from broader studies of Spanish documentary cinema—an exclusion that not only reflects a lack of awareness of this particular work but also points to a wider gap in film historiography; it is worth noting that the 1930s and 1940s remain an underexplored terrain in the historiography of documentary cinema in Spain, and the disappearance of many films—due to significant losses of film heritage in the decades

that followed—largely explains this absence. This study therefore takes *Mariñeiros* as a case study through which to raise a broader methodological and historiographical question: how can film history be written when the film itself no longer exists?

As Daniel Sánchez Salas and Begoña Soto point out in their study on the beginnings of Spanish cinema, there is a "deep-rooted tendency to analyze only preserved content as the sole valid foundation for constructing a discourse on cinematography, relegating to absolute invisibility any knowledge built from the non-existence of film materials" (2023, pp. 23–24). In this context, the case of *Mariñeiros* offers a revealing entry point into the study of Spanish cinema during a period in which archival evidence is often partial or scattered. It also raises broader questions about the limits of traditional film historiography, which has tended to privilege surviving works and helped to consolidate an image of 1930s Spanish cinema as a sterile and unremarkable era, from which Buñuel emerged like a "meteor" (Gubern, 1971, p. 477). Notably, *Mariñeiros* does not appear in the most comprehensive studies of 1930s Spanish documentary cinema, nor in the various works dedicated to the CIFESA production company, reinforcing its exclusion from established historiographic narratives.[i] Although *Mariñeiros* is often briefly mentioned in the historiography of Galician cinema,[ii] to date, most of the research on José Suárez has taken place within the field of photography history.[iii]

The approach of this study aligns with contributions from New Cinema History (NCH), which can be defined as "an emerging trend in research… [that] has shifted its focus away from the content of films to consider their circulation and consumption, and to examine the cinema as a site of social and cultural exchange" (Maltby, 2011, p. 3). By shifting its focus from "film" to the broader concept of "cinema," this framework allows us to approach the cinematic phenomenon beyond the film itself, incorporating its multiple material, institutional, and social dimensions.

An NCH approach shifts attention from the film itself to the circumstances that made *Mariñeiros* posible. This raises an initial question: why was a documentary devoted to rural Galicia financed and widely distributed by Spain's leading commercial studio, CIFESA? That a film centered on regional labor and folklore was considered commercially viable may seem counterintuitive today, but it aligns with the cultural logics of its time. As this study will explore, Spanish documentaries were frequently imagined through Spain's regional landscapes and communities, which were actively

cultivated, marketed, and aestheticized as expressions of cultural difference within a national project undergoing modernization. Such imagery was articulated at a moment when urban centers were undergoing rapid modernization, projecting onto regions beyond the cosmopolitan hubs an agrarian and traditional past.

This study proceeds from the recognition that this symbolic convergence between the rural and the regional was an active part of the dynamics of the visual imaginary: a mode of representation in which distance from urban centers was associated with rural structures and cultural forms imagined as unchanged and rooted in tradition. From this perspective, the terms rural, regional, ethnographic, and folkloric are used with a degree of interchangeability in order to analyze how such representations were constructed and circulated in the 1930s and 1940s. In this context, CIFESA's commission reflected a broader cultural investment: one made manifest in the emergence of *cine hispano*, which turned regional difference into a defining feature of Spanish cinema and a means of differentiating it within the global film market.

The conditions that made *Mariñeiros* possible, however, do not fully explain its historical significance. Produced during the Second Republic and re-released under Francoism, *Mariñeiros* illustrates how cultural artifacts could be detached from their original context and become a malleable canvas reformulated over time according to the ideological coordinates of each period. Tracing the film's successive uses reveals not only the persistence of regional imagery but also the broader processes of resignification that characterized Spanish film culture during a period of profound political transformation.

The aim of this project is to recover and reconstruct the history of *Mariñeiros*, using it as a case study to examine the evolution of documentary cinema in Spain from the Second Republic, through the Civil War, and into the early years of the Franco regime. By placing the fragmentary remains of this documentary within the framework of a visual culture oriented toward the documentation of folklore, the study analyzes how representations of regional identity were shaped, appropriated, and transformed by shifting political contexts. Through a critical engagement with non-filmic primary sources, I demonstrate how these fragments can shed light not only on the history of documentary cinema, but also on broader questions related to historiographic method, recovery, and cultural memory.

Mariñeiros in Context: Ethnographic Documentaries in the Second Republic

In a pre-industrial Spain, folkloric images became sites of symbolic contestation where competing visions of Spain and its constituent regions were negotiated. Seeking to mitigate the anxieties of modernity, "modern Spaniards went looking for answers to their contemporary political crises" in their documentation of rural life (Mendelson, 2005, p. xxix). What may at first seem paradoxical—drawing on various expressions of regional culture to shape a modern Spanish identity—was, in fact, a point of convergence for the documentary production of the period.

The commercialization of folkloric cinema reveals a broader dissemination of these representations within Spanish society. As Román Gubern observes, the 1930s marked the first time that "the problems of rural Spain entered the public debate on a large scale," a phenomenon that directly contributed to what he calls "golden years for the *españolada* in national cinema" (1977, p. 128). Although documentary cinema differed from the fictional *españolada*—a popular cinematic style later closely associated with Francoism—both were part of a shared *cine hispano* imaginary centered on the representation of regional life.

The formation of *cine hispano*—Spanish-language films adapted to the specificities of Hispanic identity—was key to the development of a Spanish cinema rooted in its regional identities, whose imagery was widely consumed and distributed. As Emeterio Díez Puertas argues, the 1931 Hispano-American Congress of Cinematography marked the institutional birth of *cine hispano*, formalized through bilateral agreements designed to counter the perceived threat of Hollywood productions, which failed to reflect the nuances of Hispanic identity (2017, p. 19). "In this sense," Díez Puertas claims, "we can say that Hollywood invented *cine hispano*" (2017, p. 33). These protectionist policies created a framework in which national film production could thrive despite international competition. The goal was to assert a local specificity against Hollywood, positioning regional culture as a commercially viable and competitive differentiator in the Spanish-speaking market.

Despite its association with depictions of "a Catholic country of cheerful people, beautiful women, distinctive music, and exotic, colorful, and luminous settings… [that] conceal poverty, *caciquismo*, clericalism, and machismo" (Díez Puertas, 2017, p. 95),

cine hispano took on diverse forms. While it is often linked to the *españolada* genre, this reading tends to focus on fiction films and oversimplifies a more heterogeneous field. The *cine hispano* model also paved the way for documentary representations, which were often characterized by strong stylization or political undertones. Examining the nonfiction cinema of this period allows for a more nuanced understanding of Spanish film production in the 1930s.

The production company CIFESA played a fundamental role in shaping this cinematic landscape and in developing the infrastructure that supported the various strands of *cine hispano*. Although recognized primarily for its commercial fiction films, CIFESA was also an important distributor of documentaries during the Republic—particularly those with ethnographic themes—which were intended to be programmed alongside fiction films in cinemas (Gubern, 1996, p. 50). Yet CIFESA's involvement in documentary production extended beyond strictly commercial concerns. Through its support of nonfiction cinema, CIFESA became a patron of filmmakers and intellectuals whose projects often intersected with avant-garde aesthetics and the cultural ambitions of the Republic.

These ventures offer a revealing entry point into the history of CIFESA, a company that had its roots in the conservative, Catholic Valencian bourgeoisie and would later align closely with Francoist cultural policy in the postwar period. The intellectual circles frequented by Vicente Casanova, its founder, and the initiatives he chose to support highlight the ideological ambivalence that ran through the cultural sphere of the Republic. Casanova participated in left-leaning intellectual circles, attended screenings at the cine-club of the Federación Universitaria Escolar (FUE), and maintained close ties with figures such as the Republican filmmaker Carlos Velo, whose films he financed (Gubern, 1996, p. 49). At the same time, Casanova openly admired the Nazi regime: in a 1935 article for *Popular Film*, he praised German cinematic progress as the result of its nationalist spirit, social optimism, and collective faith in Hitler—values that, he argued, Spain should emulate (Fanés, 1982, p. 64). Such relationships highlight the fluidity of the Republican cultural sphere, where the institutional and personal networks that sustained film production often cut across the political divisions that would later be consolidated by the Civil War.

Yet documentary cinema was not merely a vehicle through which regional realities were represented from national production centers; it was also a space in which filmmakers from the regions themselves intervened, actively shaping its forms and meanings. Suárez's work took shape at a moment when Galicia was actively reimagining itself through the cultural and political currents of *galeguismo*—a climate shaped by movements such as the *Irmandades da Fala*, associations founded in 1916 to defend the Galician language and culture, and culminating in the Galician Statute of Autonomy of 1936. In this context, rural life was frequently mobilized as a visual and cultural anchor through which filmmakers could articulate a distinctive Galician identity, even when their aims were more ethnographic than overtly political.

Exploring the local context in which *Mariñeiros* was conceived allows us to situate it within a fleeting but significant wave of Galician filmmaking. As Xan Gómez Viñas notes, the 1930s marked the first time that films made in Galicia achieved significant aesthetic depth, highlighting Antonio Román's *Canto de emigración* (1935),[iv] Carlos Velo's Galicia (1935),[v] and José Suárez's *Mariñeiros* (1936), whose contributions "occupy a central position during the Republican period" (Gómez Viñas, 2014, p. 139). Although they did not form an organized collective, their works reveal notable parallels: all three directed documentaries on Galician subjects in the mid-1930s, during the Second Republic; all three employed avant-garde formal strategies; and all three films have been lost.

It is within this constellation that *Mariñeiros* must be situated. Its focus on regional identity, artisanal labor, and the coastal landscape aligns with the wave of cultural projects that flourished during the Second Republic. Conceived both as a photographic series and a cinematic work, the film reflects a broader documentary impulse that marked the period. The fact that it was produced by CIFESA—pioneering in the development of *cine hispano* and positioned between commercial ambition and political ambiguity—underscores how the film was shaped by the ideological tensions of its time.

José Suárez and the Genesis of *Mariñeiros*

José Suárez (1902–1974) was born in Allariz, Ourense, and developed a photographic practice deeply engaged with Galician landscapes, customs, and everyday

life. While studying in Salamanca, he formed a friendship with Miguel de Unamuno, whose concept of *intrahistoria* would profoundly shape Suárez's attention rural Spain, and whom he photographed in one of his most familiar portraits (fig. 1). The closeness of their relationship is evident in *50 Fotografías de Salamanca* (1932), one of Suárez's earliest photographic projects, for which Unamuno contributed a suggestive preface: "Certain photographic views have the quality of a film reel—they do not give us a snapshot, a state, but an entire movement."

Suárez moved to Madrid shortly after completing his studies to focus fully on photography. By the mid-1930s, Suárez became a well-known photographer, with exhibitions in Madrid and Paris bringing him national and international visibility, while his photographs of Galicia increasingly came to define both his artistic practice and public image (Sendón and Suárez Canal, 2015, p. 29). This growing recognition also helped him find work as a film still photographer for CIFESA, a position that likely helped him establish the connections that would later lead to *Mariñeiros*.[vi]

In June 1936, Suárez began filming *Mariñeiros* on the coastal areas of Morrazo and Rianxo. Alongside filming, Suárez developed an eponymous photographic series, one that, as will be shown later, closely mirrored the film's characters and scenes.[vii]

Exile and Commercial Release in Argentina

The unconventional trajectory of *Mariñeiros* took an unexpected turn with the outbreak of the Spanish Civil War, when José Suárez was forced to flee Spain. At the time, the film negatives were at a laboratory in Lisbon where CIFESA regularly processed its productions. Suárez's attempts to develop the film faced numerous obstacles from CIFESA, which appears to have precipitated his decision to remove the material from the country (Suárez, 1988). During his escape, Suárez organized the clandestine transport of the reels aboard a merchant vessel bound for Argentina (Sendón and Suárez Canal, 2015, p. 37). He also took with him the camera that CIFESA had provided for the shoot, which he would later use to complete filming in Argentina.

In early 1938, *Mariñeiros* reemerged on the scene when promotional bulletins in Buenos Aires announced its forthcoming premiere, with the backing of CIFESA—suggesting a reconciliation with its author and indicating CIFESA's involvement in

promoting the film in Argentina. On February 26 of that year, the press reported that Suárez was already completing postproduction: “CIFESA announces that it will soon present a Spanish production under its label titled *Mariñeiros*” (ENERC, Arturo Sarno 01).

A letter from CIFESA addressed to the National Head of Cinematography of the Ministry of the Interior confirms its return:

> A Bourdereaux motion-picture camera belonging to our company has been sent from Buenos Aires to the Casa de España in Lisbon. This camera, which was in the custody of Don José Suárez, director of a film that we were producing in Galicia during the first days of the Movement, was removed from Spain by him and taken with him to Buenos Aires [...] We have received information that this camera is now in Spain, and we would be grateful if you would issue the necessary orders to ensure that this apparatus is returned to our possession (AGA, 21/269).

Coinciding with the return of the equipment, CIFESA hosted a luncheon in Suárez’s honor at its Buenos Aires office on April 1, 1938, to celebrate the completion of the film:

> At the offices of the distributor CIFESA, the company’s staff hosted a luncheon in honor of José Suárez, director of the Spanish documentary film *Mariñeiros*, on the occasion of the film’s completion—a task which, as is known, has been carried out in local laboratories (ENERC, Arturo Sarno 01).

By June, the press confirmed the upcoming commercial premiere of *Mariñeiros* in various Argentine cities, marking its official debut.

Argentine press sources provide some of the most detailed descriptions that survive of *Mariñeiros*, offering a rare window into the film itself. Far from being a marginal or obscure production, *Mariñeiros* premiered as the headlining feature in a high-profile promotional screening on July 29, 1938, at the Teatro Avenida in Buenos Aires. Press records describe the film as a 52-minute work, accompanied by synchronized music and brief dialogue (El Heraldo de la Cinematografista, 1938).

Press records highlight *Mariñeiros*' commercial relevance and its inclusion within a broader category of *cine hispano*, encompassing regional works that also articulated a transatlantic Hispanic identity. The film stood out as "an interesting expression of Hispanic cinema," not only because of its focus on Galician life, but also due to its resonance with Latin American audiences—particularly in Argentina, where a large Galician community found in its themes a powerful cultural connection (ENERC, Arturo Sarno 03). According to *Revista del Exhibidor*, *Mariñeiros* generated considerable anticipation: "no Spanish film has ever stirred such expectation" (1938), reflecting both CIFESA's active promotional efforts and the enthusiasm the film generated thanks to its Galician subject matter. The press promoted *Mariñeiros* extensively in Buenos Aires, where it enjoyed an extended run in theaters.

The use of the eponymous photographic series in the film's promotion lends it significant documentary value, making it one of the few visual traces that bring us closer to the film's aesthetic and mise-en-scène. There are instances in which images which correspond with the photographic series are presented in the press as previews of the film, with captions referring to them as a movie "scene" or "passage" (figs. 3-6). While we cannot confirm the extent to which the photographs align with the film's actual staging, their repeated use in the film's promotion suggests a strong visual correspondence between both projects.

Filmed with non-professional actors in the Rías Baixas region, the documentary was described as a poetic ethnography of working-class life, organized around the full cycle of maritime labor: from preparing the nets and launching the boats, to deep-sea fishing, sorting the catch, and returning home. To give the narrative emotional depth and structure, the film wove in fictionalized subplots centered on two sailors. One sailor, who leaves his young son at home, carves a toy boat during the voyage—a motif that also appears in the photographic series (fig. 7)—only to discover upon returning that the child has died. The other subplot follows a young crew member whose wife gives birth in his absence; upon his return, he meets his child in the mother's arms. Contemporary reviews noted that the emotional impact of these storylines was heightened by an original score, composed by Isidro B. Maiztegui—an Argentine of Galician descent—featuring traditional Galician melodies, choral passages, and bagpipe sections.

Several critics compared *Mariñeiros* to *Man of Aran* (1934) by Robert Flaherty (ENERC, Arturo Sarno 03), already established at the time as a canonical reference in international documentary discourse. Beyond any direct influence, however, the Argentine press invoked Flaherty to position *Mariñeiros* within a recognizable genre of ethnographic realism—one that valued locality, labor, and elemental struggle as cinematic themes.

The press also used the film's long and dramatic production process as a promotional strategy. One article claimed: "it constitutes the first known case in the history of cinematography, given that it will be seen first in our country and only afterward in the country of its origin" (ENERC, Arturo Sarno 01). However, press accounts varied significantly regarding how the film ultimately reached Argentina. Some made general references to the transportation of the negatives following the outbreak of the conflict: "the image negatives […] were brought from Spain after work was interrupted by the civil war" (Revista del Exhibidor, 1938). Others, such as the Argentine newspaper *Cinegraf*, offered a version in which the Spanish government had authorized the transfer:

> About a year ago, Spanish director José Suárez made a film in the Galician port of Bueu about the lives of the mariñeiros. Before the negative could be developed, the revolution broke out and it was impossible to deliver it to the dismantled laboratories. Nor could it be taken out of the country. The military censorship did not know whether those reels contained a poem of the sea or an indiscreet document. The emulsions were already in danger of degrading when the national government allowed the reels to be transferred to Lisbon, where the magnificent images reproduced here were developed, lending the fishermen the appearance of officiants of a strange ritual (1937).

This article was later found among Suárez's personal belongings, with the phrase "the national government allowed" crossed out—an indication of his frustration with what he perceived as a politically motivated version of events (Sendón and Suárez Canal, 2015, p. 37). This divergence highlights the political tensions surrounding authorship and control in the circulation of exile films, foreshadowing the appropriation that *Mariñeiros* would later undergo at the hands of political sectors whose interests were far removed from the film's original intent.

Spanish Civil War: Nationalist Appropriation of Mariñeiros

Despite CIFESA's evident collaboration with Suárez in the commercial distribution of the film in Argentina, this activity was increasingly accompanied by a parallel coordination with fascist sectors. While CIFESA maintained international subsidiaries that operated under both factions during the war, it moved its primary film production operations from its original headquarters in Valencia—then still under Republican control—to its branch in Seville, already in Nationalist territory. In fact, just a few months after Suárez completed the film and it premiered in Argentina, a document dated September 5, 1938, reveals that CIFESA provided a copy of *Mariñeiros* to the Falange delegation in Buenos Aires, where it was screened without any mention of Suárez's name in the program (AGA, 21/269).

Emeterio Díez Puertas has identified this screening as a propagandistic event: "It was shown at gatherings that included fascist salutes, the anthem Cara al sol, and testimonials from people who claimed they had been saved from the 'reds'... [where]... the space and time of the screening transformed José Suárez's film into a fascist film" (2017, p. 133). However, a closer examination of the documentation reveals a ticket price printed in the lower-left corner of the event poster (fig. 8), indicating that the screening was more concretely a fundraising event for the Nationalist cause during the war. Within the political context of fascist cultural diplomacy, the projection of *Mariñeiros* appears to have exploited the film's ability to evoke nostalgia for the homeland among members of the Galician diaspora in Argentina who were sympathetic to the Nationalist cause.[viii]

The omission of Suárez's name from the program coincided with the growing collaboration between the Francoist regime and CIFESA. By August of that same year, CIFESA had already been designated the official distributor of both propaganda and commercial films for the Spanish State throughout the Americas—a recognition awarded for its support of Nationalist efforts in producing wartime propaganda (fig. 9).

It was through this collaboration and the official backing it received that *Mariñeiros* continued to circulate abroad. It is difficult to determine the full extent of the film's reach, but existing references suggest a potentially broader distribution in the Americas. Press records from the Cuban newspaper *Diario de la Marina* promote the film as early as June 1937 (fig. 10), while another document from 1938 indicates that the film

was requested for distribution in El Salvador (fig. 11), whose embassy was among the first to express support for the Nationalist regime.

Postwar Spain: Commercial Distribution

Mariñeiros' role in exile and propaganda did not end in Argentina. Following the conclusion of the Spanish Civil War, press records reveal that the film continued its circulation in Spain well after its run in Argentina. Various Spanish press sources indicate that the film was promoted—omitting the director's name—and included in CIFESA's seasonal catalogs for the years 1938–1939 and 1939–1940 (*El Adelanto*, 1938; *El Día*, 1938; *La Última Hora*, 1938; *CIFESA Noticiario*, 1939). It also appeared on several occasions in CIFESA's own magazine, including a full-page spread dedicated to its images in November 1939 (fig. 12).

Despite its promotion in Spain as early as 1938, the first documented appearance of the film in Spanish theaters occurs on January 21, 1941, at Cine Novedades in Pamplona (Diario de Navarra, 1941). From that date onward, new evidence confirms that the film circulated more widely in 1942, with screenings in prominent venues such as the Cine Savoy in Barcelona, the Teatro Lírico in Valencia, and the Cine Llorens in Seville (ABC, 1942a, 1942b; F.E., 1942; Jornada, 1942; *La Prensa*, 1941, 1942; La Vanguardia Española, 1942). Additional press references extend this trajectory through 1944, when *Mariñeiros* reappeared in Cádiz as a complementary "short film," programmed alongside *Indias Orientales* for the premiere of *San Francisco* at the Teatro Principal (Ayer, 1944). The reference is difficult to reconcile with the 52-minute version premiered in Argentina and suggests that *Mariñeiros* circulated in more than one form, further underscoring the film's fragmented and mutable afterlife.

The re-release of *Mariñeiros* in Spain was accompanied by a coordinated promotional campaign aligned with CIFESA's investment in the *cine hispano* genre, which framed the film as a dignified representation of Galician identity and national cinema. A standardized review omitting Suarez's name, circulated across numerous newspapers (fig. 13).

Relaunches in Context: The Afterlife of Republican Documentaries

Mariñeiros can be situated within a still underexplored corpus of relaunches and reappropriations of regionally focused documentaries, activated both during the Spanish Civil War and in the early Francoist period. Documentary film was employed for propagandistic purposes by both sides in a context marked by severe shortages of raw film stock and photographic paper, the growing politicization of art, and the rise of visual realism (Mendelson, 2005). This combination of factors encouraged the intensive use of archival images—often drawn from preexisting sources—and facilitated the resignification of materials whose origin did not always align with the dominant ideological line.[ix]

Less studied, however, are the relaunches produced under early Francoism. María Luisa Ortega Gálvez, in her analysis of documentary cultures in Spain, highlights the existence of "potential threads" still to be explored, among them "the re-edits and re-releases of documentaries produced during the Republic" (2024, p. 55).[x] While ideology was not always the explicit driving force behind these redistributions, the highly charged political context and postwar led to what Ortega Gálvez terms the "heritage mutilation" of documentaries through cuts and re-editing (2024, p. 55). Fragments, names, and works of Republican origin continued to circulate—silenced, disguised, or directly reconfigured.

The systematic omission of authorship, as in the case of *Mariñeiros*, should also be understood within this context. At the same time, the film's fragmented trajectory suggests a parallel process of transformation. The *Mariñeiros* seen by audiences in Argentine commercial cinemas, at Falangist fundraising screenings, and in Spanish theatres emerging from the Civil War was, in all likelihood, not quite the same *Mariñeiros*.

The creation of the Noticiario Cinematográfico Español (NO-DO) in 1942 marked a turning point for Republican-era documentaries. It established state-controlled infrastructure for the production and mandatory exhibition of newsreels and documentaries in Spanish cinemas, effectively eliminating the possibility of producing or programming documentaries outside of this apparatus (Gubern, 2017, p. 195). Companies such as CIFESA subsequently directed their production and distribution activites towards fiction features, and Republican-era documentaries such as *Mariñeiros* gradually fell out of circulation by the mid-1940s.

Legacy

After *Mariñeiros*, Suárez continued to work across photography, journalism, and film. Yet the documentary remained an enduring point of reference. Among the materials preserved in his archive is an unproduced screenplay, *Marineros y tiburones* (Fig. 14), which revisits themes already present in *Mariñeiros*—fishermen, the toy boat, and the death of a child—while recasting them through a more explicitly political lens concerned with labor exploitation, emigration, and social disintegration. The screenplay suggests that the concerns animating Suárez's first documentary continued to occupy him long after its production and through the experience of exile.

Suárez returned to Spain in 1959, and in the years that followed, his health deteriorated and he became increasingly withdrawn. In 1974, José Suárez took his own life. An obituary published shortly thereafter recalled a friend's dismay at finding him sunk in a deep depression:

> Where is that fascinating archive I knew […] so well organized, like everything he did? […] already with his spirit broken by a shattered psyche, he told me he didn't know and didn't care (La Región, 1974).

At the time of his death, much of his work seemed destined to remain dispersed, forgotten, or lost, but in the decades that followed, Suárez's life and work have been brought back into view by his nephew, X. L. Suárez Canal, through his research and stewardship of the family archive. That work continues to resonate today: in 2026, the Real Academia Galega de Belas Artes nominated Suárez as the figure commemorated for the Día das Artes Galegas, a recognition that honors Suárez while contributing to a broader recovery of histories shaped by war and exile.

Conclusion

Mariñeiros demonstrates what can be recovered when a film is approached through its non-filmic traces. This approach situates the film within a wider fascination with folklore and regional culture that animated ethnographic filmmaking during the Second Republic. Part of the broader *cine hispano* genre, these documentaries offered a space for aesthetic experimentation and formal innovation, albeit a trajectory cut short by the Civil War. Tracing *Mariñeiros*' circulation through the Civil War and early Francoism

reveals the fragile afterlives of Republican-era documentaries, as images were transported, recontextualized, and resignified across shifting political regimes before gradually disappearing from circulation with the advent of NO-DO. In the scattered traces of *Mariñeiros* echo other broken works, other forgotten names, other interrupted memories. To give them shape, however partially, is to open a window onto a historical moment that, though partially erased, still speaks to us through its fragments.

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Endnotes

[i] See, among others: *El cine sonoro en la II República (1929–1936)* (Gubern, 1977); Fèlix Fanés, *Cifesa, la antorcha de los éxitos* (Fanés, 1982); *Imagen, memoria y fascinación: notas sobre el documental en España* (Català, Cerdán and Torreiro, 2001); and *El documental en España. Historia, estética e identidad* (Alvarado and Torreiro, 2023), all of which are standard reference works for the study of documentary cinema in Spain and which make no reference to *Mariñeiros*.

[ii] In *Historia del cine en Galicia: (1896–1984)* (García Fernandez, 1985, pp. 209–210), *Mariñeiro*s is included; and more recent authors have regularly referenced it in discussions on Galician cinema, as in Xan Gómez Viñas, "Cinema in Galicia: Beyond an Interrupted History" (2014, p. 149).

[iii] The foundational works of Xosé Luis Suárez Canal and Manuel Sendón offer a detailed reconstruction of Suárez's life and works, culminating in the exhibition catalogue *José Suárez: Uns ollos vivos que pensan* (2015). The principal scholarship on José Suárez is that of Xosé Luis Suárez Canal and Manuel Sendón, culminating in *José Suárez: Uns ollos vivos que pensan* (2015), which remains the most comprehensive reference on his life and photographic work. The most substantial study of the film *Mariñeiros* is Amelia Meléndez's article (2012), which approaches the project through an analysis of the surviving photographic series and its relation to documentary film aesthetics. While suggestive, her reading privileges formal analysis over questions of production and circulation.

[iv] Among the earliest efforts that exemplify this are *Canto de emigración* (1935) by Antonio Román. Román cited a drawing by Alfonso Daniel Rodríguez Castelao, depicting a dying migrant exiled on his deathbed, as the emotional inspiration for the film (Coira, 2004, p. 16). Though the film is also considered lost, there have been initiatives to recover it; historian Pepe Coira led a reconstruction project using preserved elements, including production photographs and the original soundtrack, which was presented at the OUFF film festival (*La Voz de Galicia*, 2022). The project reflects an inventive approach to reviving lost film heritage through evocative, fragmentary traces.

[v] Carlos Velo began work in 1935 on *Galicia* (also known as *Galicia-Finisterre*), a film that, as Miguel Anxo Fernández writes, "had the potential to open historical *galeguismo* to an artistic discipline and expressive medium like cinema" (2001, p. 174). With the support of a network of Galician intellectuals, Velo commissioned Castelao to

create the intertitles and enlisted ethnographer Xaquín Lorenzo "Xocas" to identify enclaves of rural authenticity. Like *Mariñeiros*, the film's postproduction was also disrupted by the filmmaker's exile and the film was long considered lost. The success Velo later achieved as a filmmaker in exile in Mexico helped sustain interest in his early work, and *Galicia* stands out as one of the most studied productions of 1930s Galician cinema. It was within this framework of sustained historiographic interest that the film was partially recovered in 2011, when researchers Margarita Ledo, Ramiro Ledo, and Pablo Cayuela located preserved footage in a Russian archive (2016, pp. 591–610). Thanks to this discovery, it became possible to identify the reuse of fragments of *Galicia* in the Soviet film *Ispanija* (1939), directed by Esfir Shub, as part of a practice that was far from unusual.

[vi] Although the full extent of his relationship with CIFESA is unknown, some promotional photographs for *La cura en la aldea* and *La reina mora*—digitized and cataloged by the Filmoteca de Catalunya—are attributed to José Suárez.

[vii] Still carefully preserved today in the private archive of José Suárez, the series comprises over 100 medium-format negatives (4.5x6 cm) and offers a visual trace of the film's production, serving as a rare piece of material evidence for a cinematic work now lost.

[viii] Alejandra Noemí Ferreyra has studied this kind of event in greater depth—known as *platos únicos*: paid social gatherings organized by the Falange where food and entertainment were provided, with all proceeds going toward Nationalist causes. Inspired by a strategy used in Nazi Germany, this formula was adopted in Spain in 1936 and soon exported to Falangist communities abroad (2022, p. 827).

Figure Captions

Fig. 1 Photograph of Miguel de Unamuno taken by José Suárez in La Flecha, Salamanca (1934). Private Archive of José Suárez.

Fig. 2 Letter from CIFESA to the Jefe Nacional de Cinematografía regarding a camera loaned to José Suárez for the production of *Mariñeiros*. AGA, 21/269.

Fig. 3 Photograph of sailors from the photographic series *Mariñeiros* (1936). Private archive of José Suárez.

Fig. 4 Press clipping reproducing the photograph of sailors from the photographic series *Mariñeiros* and identifying it as a scene ("pasaje") from the film, 28 July 1938. ENERC, Fondo Arturo Sarno 03.

Fig. 5 Photograph of women by the shore from the photographic series *Mariñeiros* (1936). Private archive of José Suárez.

Fig. 6 Press clipping reproducing the photograph of women by the shore from the photographic series *Mariñeiros* as a scene ("escena") from the film, 20 July 1938. ENERC, Fondo Arturo Sarno 02.

Fig. 7 Photograph of the lead character in *Mariñeiros* holding a toy sailboat, echoing a plot element described in contemporary reviews in which the protagonist fashions a toy boat for his son while at sea, from the photographic series *Mariñeiros* (1936). Private archive of José Suárez.

Fig 8. Programme pamphlet for a Falangist fundraising event featuring a screening of *Mariñeiros*, 5 September 1938. AGA, 21/269.

Fig. 9 Letter describing CIFESA as a collaborator in Francoist propaganda and the official distributor of Spanish films in the Americas, 2 October 1938. AGA, 21/269.

Fig. 10 Press clipping on *Mariñeiros* from the Cuban newspaper *Diario de la Marina*, 24 June 1937. BVPH.

Fig. 11 State document relaying a request from the Duke of Bailén, representative of the Spanish State in El Salvador, for information and copies of CIFESA's 1938–39 film catalogue, including *Mariñeiros*, 25 September 1938. AGA, 21/269.

Fig. 12 Full-page photographic spread devoted to *Mariñeiros* from the magazine *Noticiario CIFESA*, November 1939. Reproduced from the Filmoteca de Catalunya digital collection. http://hdl.handle.net/11091/24020.

Fig. 13 Review of *Mariñeiros* in the Spanish newspaper *Libertad*, 6 September 1939. BVPH.

Fig. 14 First page of José Suárez's unpublished film script *Mariñeiros y tiburones* (n.d.). Private archive of José Suárez.